

Module 9: Borders, Sovereignty, and Policy

Service Learning Project

Watching the Law Work: Immigration Court Observation and Legal Aid Support

Overview

Participate in an immigration court observation program or support a legal aid office in non-legal roles, then analyze how legal frameworks from the module operate in practice.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Explain border and enforcement concepts from observation (UG 1)
- Identify legal frameworks in live proceedings (UG 2)
- Describe enforcement and adjudication practices (UG 3)
- Understand rights issues facing respondents (UG 4)

Suggested community partners

- Immigration court watch / observation programs
- Immigration legal aid offices (file organization, interpretation logistics, reception)
- Detention visitation or hotline programs (where available and appropriate)
- Law school immigration clinics needing undergraduate support

Project steps

1. Complete the partner's observer or volunteer training, including courtroom conduct rules.
2. Observe 2–3 immigration court sessions (or serve 4+ shifts in the legal aid role).
3. Record structured observations: hearing type, representation status, interpreter access, outcomes announced (no names).
4. Connect observations to module frameworks: due process, non-refoulement, detention standards, discretion.
5. Interview one attorney or accredited representative about the gap between law on paper and law in the room.
6. Write the observation report and share aggregate observations with the partner program.

Deliverables

- Structured observation log
- 5-page legal observation report linking practice to frameworks
- Aggregate summary for the court watch program

Time commitment

14–16 hours.

Ethics requirements

No recording, no client names, no legal advice; observers follow all court and program rules.

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Observation quality and professionalism 25%	Exceptional professionalism: observation quality and professionalism is confirmed by strong partner or site feedback; the student was consistently prepared, dependable, and left the partner concretely better off.	Solid professionalism: observation quality and professionalism is confirmed by positive partner feedback; commitments were met with only minor scheduling or preparation issues.	Inconsistent professionalism: observation quality and professionalism is partially met — missed sessions, uneven preparation, or partner feedback indicating the student required significant management.	Inadequate professionalism: observation quality and professionalism is not met; commitments were unmet or the partner's experience was negative.
Accurate use of legal concepts 30%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: accurate use of legal concepts goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: accurate use of legal concepts is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: accurate use of legal concepts is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: accurate use of legal concepts is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.
Analysis of the law-in-books vs. law-in-action gap 30%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: analysis of the law-in-books vs. law-in-action gap goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: analysis of the law-in-books vs. law-in-action gap is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: analysis of the law-in-books vs. law-in-action gap is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: analysis of the law-in-books vs. law-in-action gap is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Contribution to the partner program 15%	Exceptional professionalism: contribution to the partner program is confirmed by strong partner or site feedback; the student was consistently prepared, dependable, and left the partner concretely better off.	Solid professionalism: contribution to the partner program is confirmed by positive partner feedback; commitments were met with only minor scheduling or preparation issues.	Inconsistent professionalism: contribution to the partner program is partially met — missed sessions, uneven preparation, or partner feedback indicating the student required significant management.	Inadequate professionalism: contribution to the partner program is not met; commitments were unmet or the partner's experience was negative.